ENGLISH C1 · ADVANCED GRAMMAR

Headers, tails and spoken grammar

Use headers, tails and discourse-sensitive clause organisation to manage reference and interpersonal meaning in speech. The lesson connects form, meaning, register and real editorial decisions rather than treating the pattern as an isolated rule.

THE CENTRAL IDEA

Use headers, tails and spoken grammar to introduce or clarify a topic in real-time interaction without losing grammatical reference while preserving the intended meaning and register.

Use headers, tails and discourse-sensitive clause organisation to manage reference and interpersonal meaning in speech.

MODEL

That new reporting system, is it working any better now?

header + resumptive clause | clause + tail noun phrase

6 GUIDED STAGES · 30 LEARNING DECISIONS

This complete guide combines explanation, visual reasoning, practice and feedback. Separate exercise and answer-key editions are also available from the lesson page.

LEARNING OUTCOMES

OUTCOME 1

01

Recognise the main headers, tails and spoken grammar patterns in authentic contexts.

OUTCOME 2

02

Choose a form that accurately expresses introduce or clarify a topic in real-time interaction without losing grammatical reference.

OUTCOME 3

03

Avoid errors that change time, agency, emphasis or speaker commitment.

OUTCOME 4

04

Use the structure appropriately in natural conversation, interviews and informal presentations.

Build meaning before form

Use headers, tails and discourse-sensitive clause organisation to manage reference and interpersonal meaning in speech.

What headers, tails and spoken grammar communicates

Use headers, tails and discourse-sensitive clause organisation to manage reference and interpersonal meaning in speech.

The central purpose is to introduce or clarify a topic in real-time interaction without losing grammatical reference. A successful choice therefore preserves the proposition while making the intended relationship, viewpoint or degree of commitment visible to the reader.

That new reporting system, is it working any better now?	a topic introduced before the speaker constructs the clause
It is surprisingly flexible, that new reporting system.	a referent clarified or evaluated after the complete clause
Seen Maya today?	an informal question whose missing material is obvious in context

How the pattern is built

Use this working formula: header + resumptive clause | clause + tail noun phrase. The formula is a decision path: it identifies the trigger, the clause architecture and the element that carries tense or modality.

The model “That new reporting system, is it working any better now?” shows the complete pattern in context. Rebuild the sentence from meaning to form instead of translating each word independently.

Choice	Structure	Example
Header	topic phrase + complete clause with pronoun	That new reporting system, is it working any better now?
Tail	complete clause + clarifying noun phrase	It is surprisingly flexible, that new reporting system.
Situational ellipsis	recoverable subject/auxiliary omitted	Seen Maya today?

Choose by meaning, not by surface similarity

Neighbouring structures may contain similar words but perform different jobs. Compare the three reference patterns and name the intended effect before completing the sentence.

A reliable answer explains both why the chosen form works and why a plausible alternative would change the meaning, time relation, information focus or level of certainty.

Meaning	Best route
a topic introduced before the speaker constructs the clause	Header
a referent clarified or evaluated after the complete clause	Tail
an informal question whose missing material is obvious in context	Situational ellipsis

Register, discourse and editorial control

This grammar is especially useful in natural conversation, interviews and informal presentations. Its value comes from helping the reader process a relationship efficiently, not from making the sentence sound artificially complex.

After editing, check recoverability, natural word order and consistency with the surrounding paragraph. If the marked structure creates ambiguity, return to a fuller or more neutral clause.

Reason through the pattern

The visual map moves from communicative purpose to structural trigger, then to the final clause. It keeps meaning and form visible at the same time so the learner can justify every choice.

01	02	03	04
header	resumptive clause	clause	tail noun phrase

DECIDE IN THIS ORDER

STEP 1

Decision 1

Identify the communicative purpose before selecting a form: introduce or clarify a topic in real-time interaction without losing grammatical reference.

STEP 2

Decision 2

Locate the structural trigger and match it to one of the reference patterns.

STEP 3

Decision 3

Check time reference, clause relationships, agency and speaker commitment.

STEP 4

Decision 4

Read the complete sentence in context and confirm that its register suits natural conversation, interviews and informal presentations.

STEP 5

Decision 5

Compare the result with a neutral alternative and keep the marked form only when it adds useful meaning.

Compare forms and meanings

Use the table to justify each structural choice.

Pattern	Form	Model
Header	topic phrase + complete clause with pronoun	That new reporting system, is it working any better now?
Tail	complete clause + clarifying noun phrase	It is surprisingly flexible, that new reporting system.
Situational ellipsis	recoverable subject/auxiliary omitted	Seen Maya today?

EXAMPLES AT A GLANCE

That new reporting system, is it working any better now?	a topic introduced before the speaker constructs the clause
It is surprisingly flexible, that new reporting system.	a referent clarified or evaluated after the complete clause
Seen Maya today?	an informal question whose missing material is obvious in context

COMMON ERRORS

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not omit the resumptive pronoun when the header stands outside the clause.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not treat a tail as an ordinary appositive inside formal edited prose.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not transfer situational ellipsis into contexts that require explicit formal grammar.

Recognition in context

Choose the sentence whose grammar matches the stated communicative purpose.

A1 · MEANING DECISION 1

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: a topic introduced before the speaker constructs the clause?

OPTIONS That new reporting system, is it working any better now? · It is surprisingly flexible, that new reporting system. · Seen Maya today?

A2 · MEANING DECISION 2

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: a referent clarified or evaluated after the complete clause?

OPTIONS It is surprisingly flexible, that new reporting system. · Seen Maya today? · That new reporting system, is it working any better now?

A3 · MEANING DECISION 3

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: an informal question whose missing material is obvious in context?

OPTIONS Seen Maya today? · That new reporting system, is it working any better now? · It is surprisingly flexible, that new reporting system.

A4 · INTERPRETATION 4

What does “That new reporting system, is it working any better now?” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS a topic introduced before the speaker constructs the clause · a referent clarified or evaluated after the complete clause · an informal question whose missing material is obvious in context

A5 · INTERPRETATION 5

What does “It is surprisingly flexible, that new reporting system.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS a referent clarified or evaluated after the complete clause · an informal question whose missing material is obvious in context · a topic introduced before the speaker constructs the clause

A6 · INTERPRETATION 6

What does “Seen Maya today?” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS an informal question whose missing material is obvious in context · a topic introduced before the speaker constructs the clause · a referent clarified or evaluated after the complete clause

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

02 · PRACTICE STAGE

Form and function

Identify both the structural family and the meaning carried by each model.

B1 · FORM AND FUNCTION 1

“That new reporting system, is it working any better now?” uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Header / Tail / Situational ellipsis · Gap 2: a topic introduced before the speaker constructs the clause / a referent clarified or evaluated after the complete clause / an informal question whose missing material is obvious in context

B2 · FORM AND FUNCTION 2

“It is surprisingly flexible, that new reporting system.” uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Tail / Situational ellipsis / Header · Gap 2: a referent clarified or evaluated after the complete clause / an informal question whose missing material is obvious in context / a topic introduced before the speaker constructs the clause

B3 · FORM AND FUNCTION 3

“Seen Maya today?” uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Situational ellipsis / Header / Tail · Gap 2: an informal question whose missing material is obvious in context / a topic introduced before the speaker constructs the clause / a referent clarified or evaluated after the complete clause

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Guided discourse choices

Maintain accurate form and meaning across a connected sequence of decisions.

C1 · EDITORIAL PLANNING

Choose the model that expresses a topic introduced before the speaker constructs the clause: _____. Choose the model that expresses a referent clarified or evaluated after the complete clause: _____. Choose the model that expresses an informal question whose missing material is obvious in context: _____. Choose the model built with topic phrase + complete clause with pronoun: _____. Choose the model built with complete clause + clarifying noun phrase: _____. Choose the model built with recoverable subject/auxiliary omitted: _____.

_____
_____

WORD BANK

Available forms

It is surprisingly flexible, that new reporting system. · Seen Maya today? · That new reporting system, is it working any better now?

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

04 · PRACTICE STAGE

Open reconstruction

Recover the missing structural trigger without a word bank.

D1 · INDEPENDENT RECONSTRUCTION

_____, is it working any better now? It is surprisingly flexible, _____. _____? State the full structural pattern for Header: _____. State the full structural pattern for Tail: _____.

_____
_____
_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Controlled transformation

Rewrite the neutral source so that it performs the requested advanced function.

E1 · TRANSFORMATION 1

Rewrite “Is the new reporting system working better?” using the Header pattern to express a topic introduced before the speaker constructs the clause.

_____
_____

E2 · TRANSFORMATION 2

Rewrite “That new reporting system is surprisingly flexible.” using the Tail pattern to express a referent clarified or evaluated after the complete clause.

_____
_____

E3 · TRANSFORMATION 3

Rewrite “Have you seen Maya today?” using the Situational ellipsis pattern to express an informal question whose missing material is obvious in context.

_____
_____

E4 · TRANSFORMATION 4

Rewrite “Is the new reporting system working better?” using the Header pattern to express a topic introduced before the speaker constructs the clause.

_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Communicative production

Use the grammar independently in realistic academic, professional and conversational contexts.

F1 · PRODUCTION TASK 1

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Header to express a topic introduced before the speaker constructs the clause, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F2 · PRODUCTION TASK 2

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Tail to express a referent clarified or evaluated after the complete clause, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F3 · PRODUCTION TASK 3

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Situational ellipsis to express an informal question whose missing material is obvious in context, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

07 · RETRIEVAL

Final self-check

Complete these prompts without reopening the guide.

R1 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: communicative purpose.

_____
_____
_____

R2 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: structural trigger.

_____
_____
_____

R3 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: meaning contrast.

_____
_____
_____

R4 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: register choice.

_____
_____
_____

Recognition in context

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

A1

That new reporting system, is it working any better now?

Header is the best match because a topic introduced before the speaker constructs the clause.

A2

It is surprisingly flexible, that new reporting system.

Tail is the best match because a referent clarified or evaluated after the complete clause.

A3

Seen Maya today?

Situational ellipsis is the best match because an informal question whose missing material is obvious in context.

A4

a topic introduced before the speaker constructs the clause

The Header pattern communicates a topic introduced before the speaker constructs the clause.

A5

a referent clarified or evaluated after the complete clause

The Tail pattern communicates a referent clarified or evaluated after the complete clause.

A6

an informal question whose missing material is obvious in context

The Situational ellipsis pattern communicates an informal question whose missing material is obvious in context.

Form and function

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

B1

Header / a topic introduced before the speaker constructs the clause

The structure belongs to the Header pattern. Its communicative purpose is a topic introduced before the speaker constructs the clause.

B2

Tail / a referent clarified or evaluated after the complete clause

The structure belongs to the Tail pattern. Its communicative purpose is a referent clarified or evaluated after the complete clause.

B3

Situational ellipsis / an informal question whose missing material is obvious in context

The structure belongs to the Situational ellipsis pattern. Its communicative purpose is an informal question whose missing material is obvious in context.

Guided discourse choices

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

C1

That new reporting system, is it working any better now?

Header: topic phrase + complete clause with pronoun.

C2

It is surprisingly flexible, that new reporting system.

Tail: complete clause + clarifying noun phrase.

C3

Seen Maya today?

Situational ellipsis: recoverable subject/auxiliary omitted.

C4

That new reporting system, is it working any better now?

Header: topic phrase + complete clause with pronoun.

C5

It is surprisingly flexible, that new reporting system.

Tail: complete clause + clarifying noun phrase.

C6

Seen Maya today?

Situational ellipsis: recoverable subject/auxiliary omitted.

Open reconstruction

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

D1

That new reporting system

Header requires “That new reporting system” in this model. topic phrase + complete clause with pronoun.

D2

that new reporting system

Tail requires “that new reporting system” in this model. complete clause + clarifying noun phrase.

D3

Seen Maya today

Situational ellipsis requires “Seen Maya today” in this model. recoverable subject/auxiliary omitted.

D4

topic phrase + complete clause with pronoun

Header is built as topic phrase + complete clause with pronoun.

D5

complete clause + clarifying noun phrase

Tail is built as complete clause + clarifying noun phrase.

Controlled transformation

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

E1

That new reporting system, is it working any better now?

topic phrase + complete clause with pronoun. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended header effect.

E2

It is surprisingly flexible, that new reporting system.

complete clause + clarifying noun phrase. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended tail effect.

E3

Seen Maya today?

recoverable subject/auxiliary omitted. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended situational ellipsis effect.

E4

That new reporting system, is it working any better now?

topic phrase + complete clause with pronoun. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended header effect.

Communicative production

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

F1

That new reporting system, is it working any better now? The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses topic phrase + complete clause with pronoun accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F2

It is surprisingly flexible, that new reporting system. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses complete clause + clarifying noun phrase accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F3

Seen Maya today? The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses recoverable subject/auxiliary omitted accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

Diagnose the pattern, not only the score

Use this page to decide what to revisit in the complete guide.

CHECK · TRIGGER OR CONTEXT

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · AUXILIARY OR STRUCTURAL CHOICE

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MAIN VERB OR CLAUSE FORM

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MEANING AND REGISTER

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____